

The Politics of the Far Right

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Summer 2026

Course

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Office Hours Tuesdays 3-5pm

In person or on Zoom

Course Objectives

This course has three interconnected aims.

First, to introduce you to the social-scientific study of the far right as a global political phenomenon. You will encounter classic and contemporary scholarship from political science, sociology, communication studies, and history. You will learn to distinguish among different families of far-right movements (fascist, populist, and/or accelerationist, etc.) and to evaluate debates about how these categories should be defined and applied. By the end of the course, you should be able to read a scholarly article about the far right and assess its claims, evidence, and methods; you should also be able to identify the implicit theoretical commitments that different scholars bring to the subject.

Second, to equip you to conduct independent research on a far-right movement of your choice. The course is built around a semester-long research project in which you will select a movement, investigate its history and contemporary characteristics, and analyze it through the social-science lenses we develop together. This project is not a book report. It asks you to think like a social scientist: to formulate questions, evaluate sources, weigh evidence, and construct an argument. The skills you develop here, involving finding and assessing scholarly sources, moving between case-specific detail and general theory, communicating complex ideas to an educated audience, are transferable to almost any subsequent intellectual or professional endeavor.

Third, to ask what kind of thing the far right is and what kind of explanation it requires. This is the animating puzzle of the course. Is the far right best understood as a recurrence of 20th-century fascism, or something novel? As a response to material conditions (economic precarity, immigration), or to cultural and psychological forces (status threat, resentment)? As a product of elite strategy, grassroots mobilization, or technological change? These are not merely academic questions. How we explain the far right shapes how we

judge it, how we predict its trajectory, and how we imagine responding to it. The course does not aim to settle these debates. It aims to make you a more sophisticated participant in them.

A note on what this course is not: It is not a history of the far right, though history is essential to it. It is not a normative critique of far-right politics, though the materials we study describe movements that advocate violence, undermine democratic institutions, and target marginalized groups. The course's purpose is analytical: to understand how and why far-right movements emerge, mobilize, and exert influence. That analytical stance is itself a political choice, and it is one we will discuss openly. But the primary work of the course is to equip you with conceptual tools and empirical knowledge, not to prescribe conclusions.

Assignments and Grading

- Three Short Reflection Papers/Class Contributions (10% of the final grade each)

This assignment involves choosing three class sessions and writing a 1-2 page reflection on what you regard as the most interesting ideas, questions, and topics raised by the readings. You may also choose to highlight areas of disagreement you have with the authors, or areas that you would like to see explained further or developed more in other work. Submit the reflection paper at least two hours before class, and be prepared to help guide some conversation around the topics you've raised! This doesn't mean that you will be asked to lecture, but you will be asked to discuss your insights, questions, or critiques and to bring other class members into conversation with your points. For these sessions, it is necessary to do more in-depth reading across the whole list of assigned material than will be the case for the rest of the class sessions.

- Annotated Bibliography on Far-Right Movement (15% of the final grade)

The remaining three assignments involve applying ideas from the course to a far-right movement of your choice from somewhere in the world. This will involve describing the history, trajectory, and key defining features of that movement, but it will also involve looking at the movement through at least some of the social-science perspectives that structure our class.

To do this, your first task is to assemble an annotated bibliography on the movement. This task prepares you for your presentation by allowing you to dive into the research behind the topic you will present, and by helping you build the expertise to field the questions the instructor and/or students may ask you after you finish talking. You should find high-quality sources that describe (1) the history of the movement, (2) the movement's current membership, strategy, behavior, and positions, and (3) social-science perspectives on the movement. The bibliography should provide at least three sources within each of these three categories. You should annotate each source with a two- to three-sentence summary of its information and why it would be useful to you.

- Preparation for Presentation (20% of the final grade)

Before presenting in class on your movement, you should demonstrate your process of preparation. Shape the material from your bibliography into a clear analysis that becomes the throughline for your presentation. If you find in doing this that you need additional research materials, feel free to pursue them.

This assignment has two components. First, submit a draft slide show that shows the planned shape and flow of the presentation, and demonstrates the way your individual voice has shaped the materials you have found into a perspective on this movement. This should be between 10 and 15 slides and should cover the same three topic areas listed in the annotated bibliography assignment.

Second, meet with Professor Seawright in office hours to discuss your planned presentation.

- Presentation on Far-Right Movement (25% of the final grade)

Teach the class about the far-right movement you have selected! Tell us about its history, its present-day political circumstances, and how social-science perspectives can help us understand it. Your presentation should be about 15 minutes, should be accessible to educated audiences who are not familiar with the subject matter, should be polished and professional, and should bring information and insight to the class!

After providing necessary background, your key objective in the presentation is to answer one of the motivating analytic questions of the course with application to the movement you have selected. I recommend focusing on one of the following questions:

1. What organizational strategies enable this far-right movement to achieve success, and what strategies hold it back? How do interactions with civil society, the internet, and existing political parties (among potentially other organizational dimensions) combine to form a strategy? What organizational features help explain the movement's relative degree of success or failure?
 2. How has the movement interacted with public opinion? Has violence been a strategy of communication, and if so in what ways and with what kinds of consequences? How has the movement engaged with propaganda and media use? With what degree of success or failure, and what explains that outcome? Does this movement fit with ideas of normalization, or does it pose challenges?
 3. How has the movement created space for itself relative to existing political movements and groupings of politicians? What ideas, messages, and strategies have been used at the level of elite politics by this movement to pursue political success? Has the movement followed the patterns we discussed with respect to far-right use of race/ethnicity, immigration, gender, and related concepts to create a political space? Why or why not? What explains the movement's relative degree of success or failure at building a spot in the political spectrum?
- Class Preparation and Participation (10% of the final grade)

Please come to each class session having closely read at least one of the readings that we will discuss in that session (you can select your focus from among the assigned readings based on your personal interests) and at least having skimmed the others, and please come in a mindset that prepares you to listen, talk, and engage in constructive learning activities!

Course Schedule and Readings

This schedule is subject to changes (minor or major) depending on how long each topic actually takes us to cover, as well as on the needs of the class.

Week 1

Fascism and Populism How should far-right movements be classified? There have been scholarly and popular debates about the appropriate labels and analogies to use in describing current far-right movements. This week's readings present two very different perspectives on some of the major labels used to describe movements of the far right. Stanley presents a vision of fascism as a movement characterized by strategic tendencies for mobilizing the public rather than a traditional ideological plan for government. Finchelstein argues that contemporary far-right movements are different from the fascist movements of the 20th century in that they accommodate themselves to electoral democracy. Instead, he describes them as populist, a kind of movement he describes theoretically and historically as the democratic evolution of fascism.

- Stanley and thinkers who agree with him describe many contemporary far-right movements as deploying fascist politics, while Finchelstein instead at most calls these movements "wannabe fascists." As you look at these texts, consider this disagreement, explore the possible reasons behind it, and think about how you might decide.

Part 1:

- Stanley, Jason. *How fascism works: The politics of us and them*. Random House Trade Paperbacks, 2020. Chapters 1-5.

Part 2:

- Finchelstein, Federico. *From fascism to populism in history*. University of California Press, 2019. Chapters 1-2.

Week 2

The 20th-Century Far-Right in Europe: Movements, Ideology, and Mobilization The contemporary far right everywhere in the world calls back to the German Nazi movement, so it is important to spend some time understanding it and its influence on subsequent movements. Popular imagination regarding the Nazis particularly emphasizes the role of Hitler and other leaders in spreading the movement's message and in exercising dictatorial control, often almost turning the movement into a one-man show. Hence, it is important to understand the ways that social organizations and communication mattered in Nazi success. The articles by Spenkuch and Tillmann and by Welch look at the construction of Nazism among the German public from two perspectives: religion and popular reaction to propaganda. The book by Camus and Lebourg connects the early 20th-century movements to the new far-right movements of the later 20th century in Europe, offering a historical narrative and explanation of the evolution from one to the other.

- In reading these materials, ask what kinds of evidence are available for each claim, and whether the arguments are persuasive.
- Ask also whether the European cases of the distant and recent past are merely symbolic references for far-right movements elsewhere in the world or whether you think they are genuine inspirations.

Part 1:

- Spenkuch, Jörg L., and Philipp Tillmann. "Elite influence? Religion and the electoral success of the Nazis." *American Journal of Political Science* 62, no. 1 (2018): 19–36.
- Welch, David. "Nazi propaganda and the Volksgemeinschaft: Constructing a people's community." *Journal of Contemporary History* 39, no. 2 (2004): 213–238.

Part 2:

- Camus, Jean-Yves, and Nicolas Lebourg. 2017. *Far-Right Politics in Europe*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press. Introduction, Chapter 1.

Week 3

The History of the US Far Right Considering the history of the far right in the US introduces a key argument of far-right studies: there is not just one kind of far-right movement. Far-right movements in the US include white-supremacist secret societies, patriot militias, anti-communist book clubs, supporters of extremist short-wave radio broadcasters, certain kinds of Satanists, distributors and fans of racist punk rock and metal, and more. These groups differ not only in terms of their social traits, but also their strategies for political change, and often their ideological goals. This week's readings address three major groupings of the historical US far right: the KKK (the articles by Byman and by McVeight, Cunningham, and Farrell), the militia movement (the article by Van Dyke and Soule) and the anticommunist movement (the book by Dallek).

- In reading, pay attention to the ways these groups differ from each other and from the Nazis and other European movements, but also the ways they are similar. Do you think it makes more sense to group these all together or to split them apart?

Part 1:

- Byman, Daniel. "White supremacy, terrorism, and the failure of reconstruction in the United States." *International Security* 46, no. 1 (2021): 53–103.
- McVeigh, Rory, David Cunningham, and Justin Farrell. "Political polarization as a social movement outcome: 1960s Klan activism and its enduring impact on political realignment in southern counties, 1960 to 2000." *American Sociological Review* 79, no. 6 (2014): 1144–1171.
- Van Dyke, Nella, and Sarah A. Soule. "Structural social change and the mobilizing effect of threat: Explaining levels of patriot and militia organizing in the United States." *Social Problems* 49, no. 4 (2002): 497–520.

Part 2:

- Dallek, Matthew. *Birchers: how the John Birch society radicalized the American right*. Basic Books, 2023. Chapters 1, 2, 11, 12.

Week 4

The Internet, Social Media, and the Changing Opportunity Structure of the Global Far Right

Everyone knows that the emergence of, first, the internet and, second, social media represent two of the major social transformations of recent decades, and it is natural to hypothesize that these enormous changes may explain the large political disruptions of the growth of the global far right. Scholars have analyzed the role of the online in the growth of the far right across a large, varied literature. This week offers several samples. The Leidig book shows how far-right women navigate the unusual incentives of the internet and their own very sexist movements to play distinctive and very powerful roles in connecting the far right with audiences who might never otherwise pay attention; I find this book one of the best recent contributions to far-right studies. The Bastos and Mercea article discusses the strategic, data-science, and ethical issues involved in detecting far-right bot networks during events such as the UK's Brexit campaign. Gomes-Franco-e Silva et al. talk about the ways that social media and the internet allow right-wing movements to change the relationships between leaders and followers. Bolet and Foos discuss experimental evidence from the UK and Australia showing that media platforming of extreme views makes them seem more popular, and that uncritical platforming leads viewers to agree with extreme positions more often.

- Across these readings, pay attention to whether it makes sense to think about the internet and social media as a single category of cause for the rise of the far right, or whether it is better to think of them as a complex bundle of different causes.
- Also try to imagine what the contemporary far right might be like without these technologies; do they make a difference?

Part 1:

- Leidig, Eviane. 2023. *The Women of the Far Right: Social Media Influencers and Online Radicalization*. New York: Columbia University Press. Chapters 1-4.

Part 2:

- Bastos, Marco, and Dan Mercea. "The public accountability of social platforms: Lessons from a study on bots and trolls in the Brexit campaign." *Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society A: Mathematical, Physical and Engineering Sciences* 376, no. 2128 (2018): 20180003.
- e Silva, Flávia Gomes-Franco, Juliana Colussi, Gabriel Bayarri-Toscano, and Paula de Souza Paes. "The Brazilian Far-right and New Media Models: the Role of Disintermediation in Bolsonarismo's Discourse." In *International Conference on Communication and Applied Technologies 2024 (ICOMTA 2024)*, pp. 255–265. Atlantis Press, 2024.
- Bolet, Diane, and Florian Foos. 2025. "Media Platforming and the Normalisation of Extreme Right Views." *British Journal of Political Science* 55: e103. doi:10.1017/S0007123425000195.

Week 5

Strategies of Mobilization I: Mainstreaming and Normalization There are a large and contentious literatures across multiple social-science disciplines regarding far-right mainstreaming and normalization. Here, mainstreaming refers to situations where parties from the established party system adopt ideas from or form coalitions with the far right, while normalization refers to changes in public moral and ethical standards in which far-right ideas and actors move from being outrageous and beyond the pale to being accepted as part of the normal political spectrum. While there are many perspectives and arguments made regarding these questions, Valentim's book is one of the major current touchpoints of these debates and presents a thorough theory of changes in citizen belief and behavior, experimental evidence to test that theory, and puts this together into something of a general theory of the rise of the far right.

- In reading Valentim, ask what you find persuasive about his theory and evidence, what you disagree with, and where you would like to see additional evidence.

Pal offers a very different explanation for normalization, using evidence about organizational networks from India to argue that normalization results from strategies of social penetration and civil-society organizing. Bischof and Wagner use Dutch data to suggest that far-right victories may increase polarization, rather than simple normalization. - Compare these findings to Valentim's argument; is this a situation where all three might be correct at once, or is it a case where we have to choose sides?

Part 1:

- Valentim, Vicente. 2024. *The Normalization of the Radical Right: A Norms Theory of Political Supply and Demand*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. doi:10.1093/9780198926740.001.0001. Chapters 2, 4, and 8.

Part 2:

- Pal, Felix. "Organizational Diffusion: What India Tells Us about How the Far Right Wins." *Politics & Society* 53.2 (2025): 210-242.
- Bischof, Daniel, and Markus Wagner. "Do voters polarize when radical parties enter parliament?." *American Journal of Political Science* 63.4 (2019): 888-904.

Week 6

Strategies of Mobilization II: Violence and Accelerationism Far-right movements in the world in recent decades have a profound reputation for violence. Social-science research often focuses on the point of view that political violence is neither a side effect of a movement nor a mistake, but rather a strategy that movements sometimes use to achieve goals. If that might be true, what could violence be doing for the far right? The readings in this week's section offer a range of different perspectives. Aarons analyzes the idea of "accelerationism," a far-right tendency that celebrates violence and murder as pure action, the inherent realization of the movement's vision. Piatkowska and Stults ask what kinds of events (domestic, international, etc.) predict upswings of right-wing violence in the UK. Koopmans analyzes the level of far-right violence across Western Europe, arguing that levels of immigration and other right-wing grievances do little to predict violence but that the political strength of the far right is a powerful predictor. Arnold and Markowitz present evidence for a process of learning over time that has changed the form and targeting and increased the level of right-wing violence in Russia. Hardy and Henschke analyze posts on neo-Nazi online forum Stormfront to learn how participants talk about violence. Finally, Gouveia critically analyzes the common right-wing argument that violence is necessary in order to repress crime and establish order, looking particularly at a Brazilian context.

- Reading across these quite different analyses asking questions about diverse dimensions of violence, consider whether the evidence suggests that far-right movements and participants are using violence for deliberate, strategic goals, or whether some other explanation (frustration? pure anger? irrationality?) might better account for the behavior.
- If the behavior seems deliberate and strategic, what are the strategies?
- Are there possible interventions that might reduce violence?

Part 1:

- Aarons, Kieran. "Genealogy of Far-Right Accelerationism." (2023). <https://philpapers.org/archive/ARGOF.pdf>
- Piatkowska, Sylwia J., and Brian J. Stults. "Brexit, terrorist attacks, and hate crime: A longitudinal analysis." *Social Problems* 69.4 (2022): 968-996.
- Koopmans, Ruud. "Explaining the rise of racist and extreme right violence in Western Europe: Grievances or opportunities?" *European Journal of Political Research* 30, no. 2 (1996): 185-216.

Part 2:

- Arnold, Richard, and Lawrence P. Markowitz. "The evolution of violence within far-right mobilization: evidence from Russia." *Ethnic and Racial Studies* 41, no. 9 (2018): 1558-1573.

- Hardy, John, and Adam Henschke. “A gathering storm: offensive and defensive accelerationism in an online far-right community.” *Dynamics of Asymmetric Conflict* 17, no. 3 (2024): 200–220.
- Gouveia Junior, Luís. “Milicias in Rio de Janeiro: deconstructing the myth of a violent everyday peace through a feminist perspective.” *Frontiers in Political Science* 6 (2024): 1466098.

Week 7

The Far Right and the Politics of Gender: Patriarchy, Pronatalism, and Anti-Gender Ideology

We have already at this point encountered ways in which the far right puts female adherents in complex dilemmas. This week’s readings focus in on these dilemmas. Blee focuses on the ways in which traditional images of the far right as male become an obstacle to understanding, and suggests new ways of thinking that may reveal the ways women operate within the far right. Anduiza and Rico discuss a form of modern sexism that, they show, may motivate individual voters (male and female) in supporting far-right candidates, using evidence from Spain. Brady analyzes US discourse about natalism during the Trump era to explore how ideas about the prototypical white mother citizen can be used as weapons against others. Corredor analyzes “gender ideology” as a transnational right-wing response to feminist, LGBTQ+, and other social-policy and public-opinion victories.

- In reading these, ask whether gender is an additional lens that is useful to bring in thinking about the far right, or whether it is an essential component of these movements.
- Are women, LGBTQ+ people, the childless, and others inherent threats to the far right, convenient targets, uncomfortable representatives of social change, or something else?

Part 1:

- Blee, Kathleen M. “Does gender matter in the United States far-right?” *Politics, Religion & Ideology* 13, no. 2 (2012): 253–265.
- Anduiza, Eva, and Guillem Rico. “Sexism and the far-right vote: The individual dynamics of gender backlash.” *American Journal of Political Science* 68, no. 2 (2024): 478–493.

Part 2:

- Brady, Miranda J. “Citizen mothers and others: natalist discourse and politics in the US after Trump.” *Social Identities* (2025): 1–22.
- Corredor, Elizabeth S. “Unpacking ‘gender ideology’ and the global right’s antigender countermovement.” *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society* 44, no. 3 (2019): 613–638.

Week 8

The Far Right and Ethnic Identity: Ethnocentrism, Immigration, and Whiteness One of the defining traits of far-right politics is a politics of group. Almost everywhere, this takes on an ethnic dimension. In much but not quite all of the world, the far right has united around a rejection of immigrants. Sometimes, a political advocacy of white nationalism (and/or anti-indigenous politics) coexists with or stands in place of anti-immigrant politics. Blee and Yates helpfully remind us that far-right movements differ in their use of race; some make racial appeals implicit, while others are open and explicit. Dixit analyzes the way that US extremists have used as a justification for violence the idea of a “great replacement” in which outsiders are taking the allegedly rightful roles of white men. Dinas, Matakos, Xefteris, and Hangartner use evidence from Greece to argue that experiencing a refugee crisis might help explain the rise in votes for the far right. Magni uses experimental evidence from United States, the United Kingdom, France, and Italy to show the importance of anti-immigrant attitudes in shaping public opinion about welfare, and to argue that immigrants with long work histories face less negative opinion. Halikiopoulou and Vlandas suggest that opposition to immigration can have both a cultural and an economic dimension, and present evidence to argue that the economic dimension is more important to the political success of the far right in Europe.

- Looking across these articles, a useful integrative perspective is to ask whether the far-right movements that achieve the most success have tended to be those that make race more explicit, or those that make race more implicit?

- How central is the politics of race compared with other issues that might explain the rise of the far right?
- Is the argument that group politics has been central to the far right compelling or overstated?

Part 1:

- Blee, Kathleen M., and Elizabeth A. Yates. “The place of race in conservative and far-right movements.” *Sociology of Race and Ethnicity* 1, no. 1 (2015): 127–136.
- Dixit, Priya. “Red pills, white genocide, and ‘the great replacement’: Rewriting history, and constructing white victimhood in/through far-right extremist manifestos and texts.” In *Race, Popular Culture, and Far-right Extremism in the United States*, pp. 173–205. Cham: Springer International Publishing, 2022.

Part 2:

- Dinas, Elias, Konstantinos Matakos, Dimitrios Xefferis, and Dominik Hangartner. 2019. “Waking Up the Golden Dawn: Does Exposure to the Refugee Crisis Increase Support for Extreme-Right Parties?” *Political Analysis* 27(2): 244–54. doi:10.1017/pan.2018.48.
- Magni, Gabriele. “Boundaries of solidarity: Immigrants, economic contributions, and welfare attitudes.” *American Journal of Political Science* 68, no. 1 (2024): 72–92.
- Halikiopoulou, Daphne, and Tim Vlandas. “When economic and cultural interests align: The anti-immigration voter coalitions driving far right party success in Europe.” *European Political Science Review* 12, no. 4 (2020): 427–448.

Week 9

The Transnational Far Right: Network-Building Strategies and Patterns of Collaboration Far right movements are nationalist. They stand against the “globalists,” and they honor the individual identities of the powerful cultures at their core. Social scientists therefore find it deeply ironic that the current wave of far-right movements appear to be powerfully networked around the globe. Heft, Knüpfer, Reinhardt, and Mayerhöffer study this networking from a communications perspective, looking at the degree of transnational linkage between right-wing news sites in various European countries and the US. Roumanias, Lamprini, and Georgiadou ask whether far-right electoral success is contagious, showing quantitative evidence from European elections to argue that it might be. Turnbull-Dugarte and Rama offer clever, focused evidence showing that Trump’s 2020 defeat may have spilled over to Spain to reduce support for that country’s far-right party. Giani and Méon show from survey responses in Europe that individual levels of racism across the continent may have measurably increased in the days following Trump’s 2016 electoral victory. Wojczewski analyzes the ideological appeals that far-right actors have used on the international stage in order to try to form a broad coalition “of the ‘native people’ against ‘globalists’, ‘foreigners’, ‘immigrants’ and ‘minorities’.” Cabrera-Cuadrado and Chrobak focus on a specific relationship, between the US right and Hungary’s Victor Orban, arguing that the huge increase in praise for Orban among American conservatives and far-right leaders is in part a victory of Orban’s personalistic public diplomacy.

- These different perspectives show transnational linkages among far-right movements, but at different levels. Ask these readings: are cross-national linkages mostly made by presidents, party leaders, and public officials; by journalists, online influencers, and celebrities; or by voters, citizens, and other ordinary individuals?

Part 1:

- Heft, Annett, Curd Knüpfer, Susanne Reinhardt, and Eva Mayerhöffer. “Toward a transnational information ecology on the right? Hyperlink networking among right-wing digital news sites in Europe and the United States.” *The International Journal of Press/Politics* 26, no. 2 (2021): 484–504.
- Roumanias, Costas, Lamprini Rori, and Vasiliki Georgiadou. “Far-right domino: Towards an integrated framework of political contagion.” *Electoral Studies* 76 (2022): 102442.
- Turnbull-Dugarte, Stuart J., and José Rama. “When the US far-right sneezes, the European far-right catches a cold. Quasi-experimental evidence of electoral contagion from Spain.” *Electoral Studies* 76 (2022): 102443.

Part 2:

- Giani, Marco, and Pierre-Guillaume Méon. “Global racist contagion following Donald Trump’s election.” *British Journal of Political Science* 51, no. 3 (2021): 1332–1339.
- Wojczewski, Thorsten. “The international cooperation of the populist radical right: building counter-hegemony in international relations.” *International Relations* (2024): 00471178231222888.
- Cabrera-Cuadrado, Carla, and John Chrobak. “Illiberalism and the deinstitutionalization of public diplomacy: The rise of Hungary and Viktor Orbán in American conservative media.” *Communication & Society* (2023): 311–324.